

Module 5: Cybercrime Case Study Analysis

Topic: RTO E-Challan Phishing Scam (Gondia/Bhandara Incident)

Student Name: Pranav Raghuvanshi | **Reg No:** 25BCY10108

Course: Digital Literacy (CSE) | **University:** VIT Bhopal University

1. Executive Summary of the Incident

A major cyber fraud incident recently occurred in the Gondia/Bhandara region of Maharashtra, as reported by ABP Majha. A victim lost **₹5 lakh** after interacting with a malicious link disguised as an official RTO (Regional Transport Office) communication regarding an unpaid traffic fine. This case highlights the increasing sophistication of local-level phishing attacks in India and the vulnerability of citizens to social engineering.

2. Definition of the Crime

The crime identified in this case is **Smishing (SMS Phishing)** combined with **Financial Identity Theft**.

- **Phishing:** A cybercrime where targets are contacted by email, telephone, or text message by someone posing as a legitimate institution to lure individuals into providing sensitive data.
- **Social Engineering:** The psychological manipulation of people into performing actions or divulging confidential information—in this case, exploiting the fear of legal penalties from the RTO to cloud the victim's judgment.

3. Modus Operandi (Step-by-Step Mechanism)

The attack followed a structured four-step process:

1. **The Initial Contact:** The victim received an SMS claiming a pending traffic violation ("E-Challan") with a specific fine amount to create immediate urgency.
2. **The Malicious Link:** The message contained a "spoofed" URL designed to look like the official Government of India Parivahan portal.
3. **The Credential Harvest:** Upon clicking the link, the victim was prompted to enter vehicle details followed by sensitive banking credentials or a UPI PIN to "clear the fine."

4. **The Unauthorized Debit:** By gaining access to the victim's session or credentials, the attackers initiated a transfer of **₹5 lakh**, moving the funds through multiple "mule accounts" to avoid immediate tracking by authorities.

4. Target Demographics

The primary targets are vehicle owners who are likely to be concerned about their driving records and legal standing. Cybercriminals often target specific geographic regions (like Maharashtra) and demographics that may lack the technical training to verify **.gov.in** URL extensions or identify the subtle signs of a fraudulent SMS.

5. Consequences and Impact

- **Financial Loss:** The immediate loss of ₹5 lakh is a devastating blow to the victim's personal savings.
- **Data Privacy:** The victim's banking information is now compromised, requiring the immediate cancellation of cards and freezing of all linked accounts.
- **Legal/Mental Stress:** Victims face a significant psychological burden and the low probability of fund recovery due to the extreme speed of digital transfers.

6. Prevention and Advisory

Based on the Gondia Police advisory and digital safety standards, the following prevention steps are essential:

- **Manual Verification:** Always check for fines directly on the official portal: <https://echallan.parivahan.gov.in/>.
- **Link Skepticism:** Never click on links provided in SMS messages. Official government domains in India always end in **.gov.in**.
- **Emergency Action:** In case of fraud, dial **1930** immediately to report the crime during the "**Golden Hour**" (the first 2 hours) to maximize the chances of freezing the stolen funds.